

Microsoft's Imagine Cup - The winners

It's Official! The Indian leg of the competition that has been the focus of attention for the past few months has finally yielded its champions. Young and innovative students from across the country proved their mettle by coming up with innovative ideas. The finale of the Imagine Cup that was held in Bangalore on May 09, 2008, gripped the audience from beginning to end and revealed the forerunners who would go ahead and represent India in the Imagine Cup World Finals in early July.

The participants who created solutions in accordance to this year's theme - Imagine a world where technology enables a sustainable environment - and that made it to the finalist list were:

Team blAnkSpace, Team Eco Warriors, Team EcoPals, Team GRAS, Team Green Waves, Team Gurus, Team Novices@Work and Team SKAN.

Ravi Venkatesan gave away the prizes to the deserving students.

Eminent dignitaries from industry and academia, like Paul Murphy, Director of Innovation, Microsoft; Kiran Karnik, Past President, NASSCOM; Prof S Sadagopan, Founder-Director, IIIT (International Institute of Information Technology) ; Ravi Venkatesan, Chairman, Microsoft India; Tarun Gulati, COO Microsoft India; Rajdeep Sehrawat, Vice President, NASSCOM; Dr Gopichand Katragadda, GM, Operations, GE Global Research Bangalore, R K Misra, Winner-Lead India and Prof. Sameer Barua, Director, IIMA, graced the event.

Sound Bytes

Speaking on the occasion, Paul Murphy discussed the pressing need for India-specific innovations rather than force fitting global innovations. "The most important aspect of Innovation is that they are of two kinds. One is necessity based and the other convenience based. If you look at the US and Western Europe, most of the innovations have been convenience based, but the true need of the hour in India is necessity based innovations".

Platforms like Imagine Cup will be instrumental in fulfilling such a need. Also, it gives tremendous opportunity for the young talent to use their knowledge and new thinking into creating solutions that will benefit the world. This gets better as such a stage helps students to make a business case of their solution and enter the corporate world.

According to Prof. S Sadgopan, when it comes to innovation, deep research doesn't necessarily bring results. In the past, small innovations have made a phenomenal difference to the life of the common man. And such innovations have not been done by noble prize winning geniuses, but by regular people. This should inspire students and the young talent in India to push themselves to think broadly and keep their eyes and ears open as we need a whole spectrum of ideas to progress as a nation.

"Change is the only constant. And that is what we are trying to do - we are trying to change India. Post Lead India we have started this initiative wherein we are trying to change the way we -

Indians think, behave and conduct ourselves. We are trying to bring about a difference, and the majority of people in the campaign are our youngsters as I believe youngsters have the capacity to think differently and be real change agents and I honestly have a lot of faith in young India", shared R K Misra. According to Tarun Gulati, "We believe in investing for the future. If the Indian IT system is enabled and if students in India have the capability and skills to realise their potential, not only Microsoft, but every company will benefit from such initiatives."

Dr R K Pachauri, Director General, TERI (The Energy and Research Institute) who was unable to attend the event due to previous engagements, sent a very inspiring message to the students. He said that environmental issues are a grave concern today and if we do not wake up to the peril, not only future generation, but also this generation will face serious consequences. Today, we need a solution which can be implemented through collective action and only youngsters can be the catalyst to push the society in the right direction. He went on to say that Imagine Cup is the right platform for such a radical movement.

In the end, a very excited Saili Dharia - member of Team Novices @Work - took the stage. "I am feeling exhilarated and I want to profusely thank all those who played a part in our success. This solution will truly benefit rural India and I want to make a sincere appeal that this should be taken up and put into practical use, as seeing it succeed will be our true reward", she signed off.



Winners

1st place Team Novices@Work

(A self-configurable wireless sensor mesh network system that monitors and analyses agricultural soil parameters that can influence crop related decisions)

2nd place Team SKAN

(A power consumption solution where the management can monitor the entire computer network and switch idle computers into the power save mode)

3rd place Team Green Waves

(A solution where citizens can take photographs of environmental issues they come across in their day-to-day lives and send them to a centralised agency, which can then disseminate the information to concerned NGOs)